to Akbar and Adam, and one he shared with Kamran – as he had once shared a washbasin and a goblet with his brother. Two nights were spent thus, 'in jollity and carousing'[62] – it was Ramzan, besides, and a time for feasting at night – but eventually the gathered chieftains staged an intervention. What was Humayun playing at? The padishah – if, indeed, he wished to be padishah – must end his troubles with Kamran the only way they could be ended: once and for all, with the sword.

According to Jouher, Humayun delayed the matter by throwing yet another party, this one to honour Sultan Adam. According to Abul Fazl, he dragged his feet until the chieftains drew up a writ, duly witnessed by jurists and clergymen, listing Kamran's misdeeds and arguing for appropriate punishment. Humayun sent the writ to Kamran, who replied: '[T]hose who today had put their seals for his death, were the men who had brought him to this pass.'

Kamran's bitterness was justified. The chieftains, cutting and running from side to side during the long fraternal strife, had hardly covered themselves in glory. Not only this, they had bullied an oath out of Humayun, making him swear compliance to their will in exchange for their loyalty. And now their will was crystal clear: 'If you wish to act as a brother, abandon the throne.'[63]

What kind of dynasty would the Mughals have been if their kings abandoned thrones? Early next morning, Humayun rode away from the camp, leaving orders that his brother be blinded in his wake.

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The faithful Jouher had spent the previous night with Kamran, giving the melancholy prince a champoo. 'Do you think they will kill me?' Kamran asked him, and would Jouher keep the remaining fasts of Ramzan on Kamran's behalf? Jouher tried to give comforting answers, but there was little he could say to lift the prince's mood.

In the morning, two men, Ali Dost and Ghulam Ali, joined Jouher in Kamran's tent and began squabbling over who should put out his eyes. An absurd horror followed, as the men passed the buck to each other as if it were a ticking bomb, each arguing with bureaucratic obduracy that while they both had instructions to blind the prince, neither had been clearly